490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 13 OF 26

Judges and Ruth

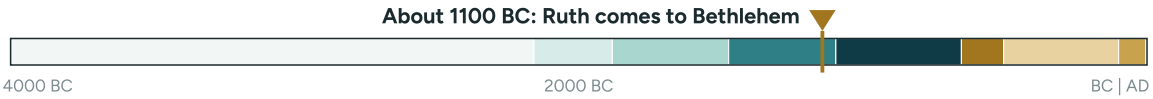
Judges 2; 6–8; 21; Ruth 1–4



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 13



Introduction: The Dark Ages of Israel

This lesson opens Unit 4, "The Kingdom." Lesson 12 ended on a high note. God had kept every promise and brought his people into the land. But it ended with a question too: would Israel finish what God had started? The book of Judges answers with a sad no. Tribe after tribe "did not drive out" the Canaanites who remained (Judg. 1:27–28). And then came a sentence that should chill anyone who has ever tried to pass on faith to their children:

> **Judges 2:10** *"And all that generation also were gathered to their fathers. And there arose another generation after them who did not know the LORD or the work that he had done for Israel."*

Moses had told parents to teach God's words to their children at home, on the road, at bedtime, and first thing in the morning (Deut. 6:7). Within one generation, it had stopped happening. What followed was more than three hundred years of spiritual chaos, roughly 1375 to 1050 BC, the dark ages of Israel's history.

But in the middle of those dark years, the Bible tucks a small, beautiful book about a widow, a foreigner, and a kind farmer. It opens, "In the days when the judges ruled" (Ruth 1:1). Judges shows how bad things got. Ruth shows what God was quietly doing anyway. This lesson puts the two side by side.

The Word: Redeemer

> **Ruth 2:20** *"And Naomi said to her daughter-in-law, 'May he be blessed by the LORD, whose kindness has not forsaken the living or the dead!' Naomi also said to her, 'The man is a close relative of ours, one of our redeemers.'"*

גֹּאֵל *(go'el, "redeemer")*

a family member who steps in to rescue a relative in trouble

Buys back land

Lev. 25:25

If a poor relative had to sell his family land, the redeemer bought it back.

Buys back people

Lev. 25:47–49

If a poor relative sold himself as a servant to a foreigner, the redeemer paid to set him free.

Keeps a name alive

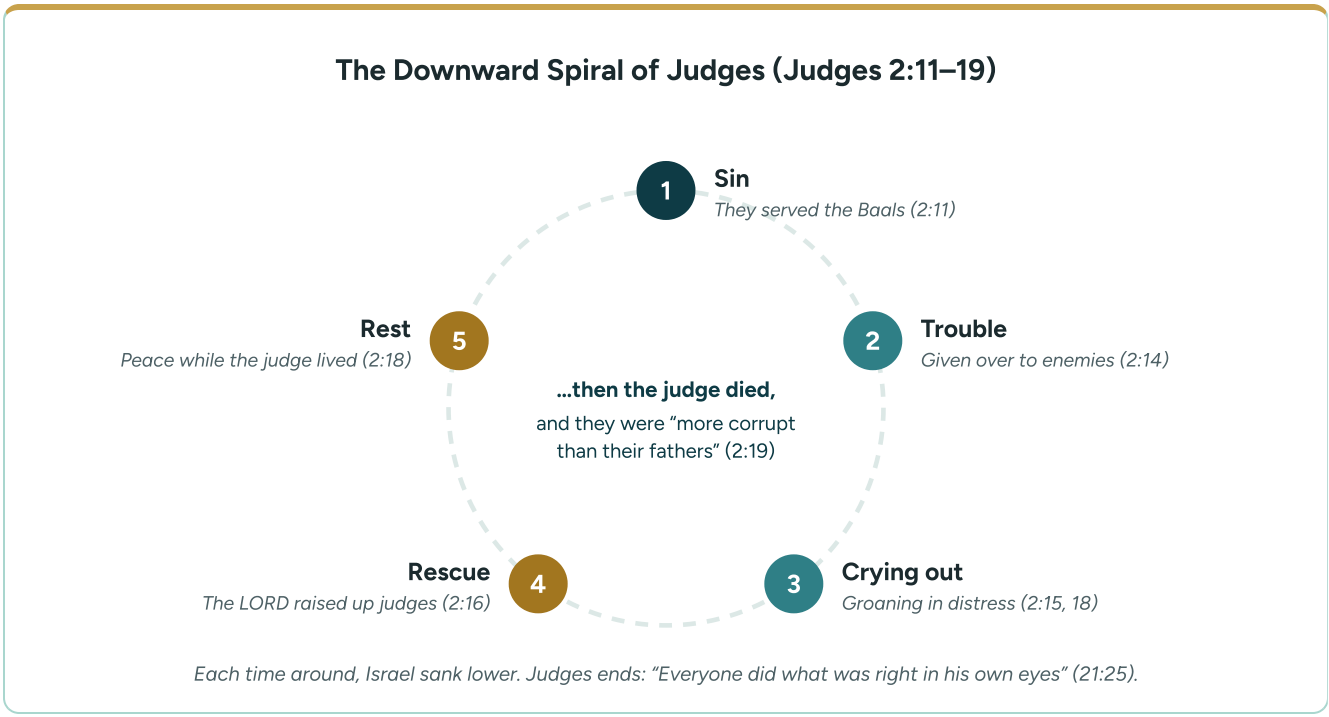
Deut. 25:5–6

If a man died childless, his brother was to marry the widow so the dead man's name would not be blotted out. Ruth 4 applies the heart of this law to a more distant relative.

Payoff: Put the redeemer laws and Ruth's story together and you see three things a redeemer needed to be: a close relative, able to pay, and willing to pay. The same word is used of God himself: "your Maker is your husband… and the Holy One of Israel is your Redeemer" (Isa. 54:5). Keep those three requirements in mind. They will lead us straight to Jesus.

Part One: The Downward Spiral

Judges 2 gives a summary of the whole book before it tells a single story. The pattern goes like this. Israel "did what was evil in the sight of the LORD and served the Baals" (2:11). God handed them over to their enemies. They were "in terrible distress" (2:15). They groaned under it (2:18), and later chapters say they cried out to the LORD (3:9). And "the LORD raised up judges, who saved them out of the hand of those who plundered them" (2:16). The land had peace while the judge lived. Then the judge died, and the people "turned back and were more corrupt than their fathers" (2:19).



The diagram draws it as a loop, but every time around, Israel sank lower. It is a spiral, and it goes down. The word "judge" here does not mean someone in a courtroom robe. These judges were mostly military rescuers whom God raised up to save his people.

Watch God's heart in this cycle. His anger burned against their idolatry, because they had broken his covenant and given his glory to idols, and those idols were destroying them. But "the LORD was moved to pity by their groaning because of those who afflicted and oppressed them" (2:18). Later, when they put away their foreign gods, the text puts it in strikingly human terms: "he became impatient over the misery of Israel" (10:16). Even when their repentance was shallow, his compassion moved him to rescue them again and again. That is grace.

Part Two: Flawed Rescuers

The first judge, Othniel, is the model: "The Spirit of the LORD was upon him, and he judged Israel.... So the land had rest for forty years" (3:10–11). After him, the rescuers get more complicated.

Deborah was a prophetess who settled Israel's disputes under a palm tree (4:4–5). Through her, God summoned Barak to lead Israel's army. Barak would not go without her, so she went, and the decisive blow fell to another woman, Jael (4:6–9, 21). Deborah's song calls her "a mother in Israel" (5:7).

Gideon was hiding from the enemy when the angel of the LORD found him, threshing wheat in a winepress and doubting God. "If the LORD is with us, why then has all this happened to us?" (6:13). He called himself the least member of the weakest clan (6:15). God cut his army from thirty-two thousand to

three hundred, so that no one could say, “My own hand has saved me” (7:2). At night the three hundred broke their jars, held up torches, blew their trumpets, and the LORD turned the enemy’s swords against each other until the whole army fled (7:19–22).



“They held in their left hands the torches, and in their right hands the trumpets to blow” (Judg. 7:20).

Afterward the people begged Gideon to be their king. He gave a great answer: “I will not rule over you, and my son will not rule over you; the LORD will rule over you” (8:23). And then he made a golden ephod, a priestly garment, and “all Israel whored after it there, and it became a snare to Gideon and to his family” (8:27). *Whored* is the Bible’s blunt word for spiritual unfaithfulness. The rescuer led them back into idolatry.

Samson had astonishing God-given strength and was one of the weakest men in the Bible. Set apart as a Nazirite “from the womb” to “begin to save Israel” (13:5), he spent much of his life chasing women and revenge. He died blind, a prisoner of the Philistines, calling on the LORD one last time and pulling their temple down on himself and them (16:28–30).

Hebrews still names Gideon and Samson among the people of faith (Heb. 11:32). That is not because God approved of everything they did. It is because God works through weak, sinful people who trust him, even a little. Every judge saved Israel for a while. None of them could change Israel’s heart, and none of them could stay. Israel needed a better rescuer.

Part Three: Right in His Own Eyes

The last chapters of Judges stop following the judges and show what ordinary life had become. A man named Micah keeps idols made from silver his mother dedicated “to the LORD” (17:3), sets up a private shrine, and hires a wandering Levite as his priest. A whole tribe steals that priest and his idols. And the book ends with a crime and a civil war so terrible that they are among the darkest chapters in the Bible (Judg. 19–21). Four times the writer says “there was no king in Israel,” and the book ends on the full line:

> **Judges 21:25** *"In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes."*

That sentence sounds almost modern. "Do what is right for you." Judges shows where it leads. When everyone becomes his own king, the weak get crushed. The book is crying out for a king who will do what is right in God's eyes and lead his people to do the same.

Part Four: Ruth: Grace in the Dark

Now turn the page to Ruth. A famine hits Bethlehem, and a man named Elimelech takes his wife Naomi and their two sons to Moab, a pagan nation east of the Dead Sea. Elimelech dies there. The sons marry Moabite women, Orpah and Ruth. About ten years later, both sons die too. Naomi is left with nothing: no husband, no sons, no grandchildren, in a foreign land.

When Naomi hears that God has given food to Bethlehem again, she starts home and tells her daughters-in-law to go back to their own families. Orpah kisses her and goes. But Ruth clings to her and says some of the most beautiful words in the Bible:

> **Ruth 1:16** *"For where you go I will go, and where you lodge I will lodge. Your people shall be my people, and your God my God."*

This is more than loyalty to a mother-in-law. It is conversion. Ruth leaves her gods for Naomi's God. And remember who she is: a Moabite. God's law said, "No Ammonite or Moabite may enter the assembly of the LORD" (Deut. 23:3). Ruth is the ultimate outsider. The law shut Moabites out of the assembly because Moab had met Israel with curses instead of bread (Deut. 23:4). Ruth comes the other way, as a Moabite who blesses Israel and takes refuge under Israel's God. The prophets later promised that foreigners who hold fast to the LORD would be welcomed into his house (Isa. 56:3–7). Ruth is an early taste of that promise. She is coming in by faith.

Back in Bethlehem, Naomi is bitter. "Do not call me Naomi" (the name means "pleasant"); "call me Mara" ("bitter"), "for the Almighty has dealt very bitterly with me. I went away full, and the LORD has brought me back empty" (1:20–21). She is honest about her pain, and the book does not scold her for it. But she is wrong about one thing. She is not empty. She has Ruth, and God is already at work.



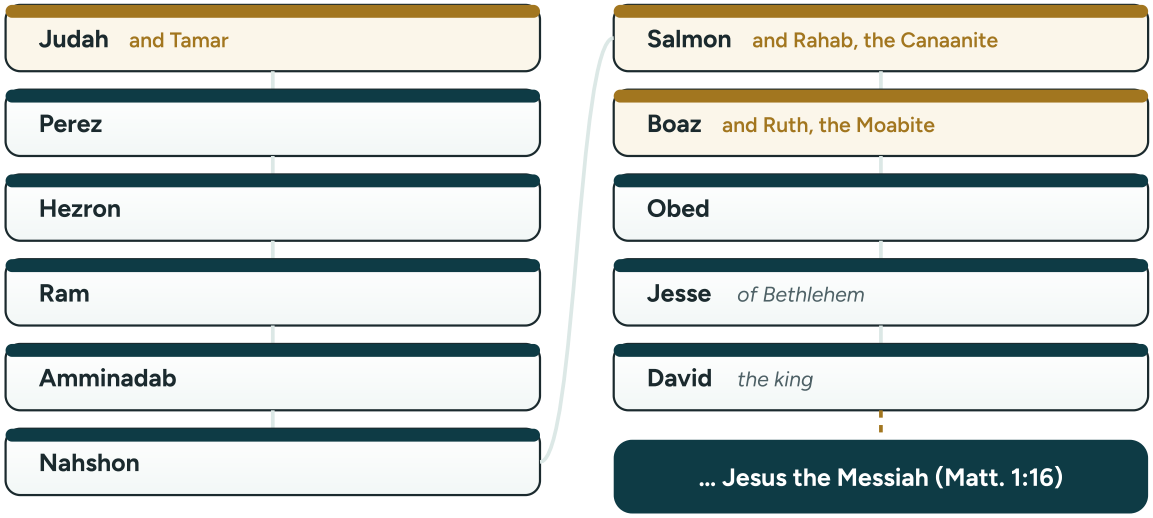
"And she happened to come to the part of the field belonging to Boaz" (Ruth 2:3).

To feed them both, Ruth goes out to glean, picking up the grain the harvesters leave behind, which God's law required farmers to leave for the poor, the foreigner, and the widow (Lev. 19:9–10; Deut. 24:19). Ruth was all three. "And she happened to come to the part of the field belonging to Boaz" (2:3). She "happened" to. The writer smiles as he says it. There are no accidents in God's world. Boaz is a relative of Naomi's late husband, and he is a good man. He protects Ruth, feeds her, and blesses her: "a full reward be given you by the LORD, the God of Israel, under whose wings you have come to take refuge!" (2:12).

At Naomi's urging, Ruth goes to the threshing floor where Boaz is sleeping beside his grain, lies down at his feet, and waits. When he wakes at midnight, she asks him to marry her, using his own words: "Spread your wings over your servant, for you are a redeemer" (3:9). The Hebrew word for "wings" also means the corner of a cloak, and spreading it over a woman was a way of promising marriage and protection (Ezek. 16:8). Boaz calls her "a worthy woman" (3:11) and sends her home before dawn with her honor protected (3:14). Boaz is willing. But there is a closer relative with the first right. Boaz meets him at the town gate, in front of the elders. That man wants the land but backs out when he learns that Ruth comes with it: "I cannot redeem it for myself, lest I impair my own inheritance" (4:6). Any son born to Ruth would carry Mahlon's name and inherit that land, so he would be paying for property his own family would never keep. Boaz pays the price himself. "Ruth the Moabite, the widow of Mahlon, I have bought to be my wife" (4:10).

The story ends with a baby on Naomi's lap. The women of the town say, "Blessed be the LORD, who has not left you this day without a redeemer" (4:14). The woman who came home empty is full again. And then the last line turns a family story into world history. The baby's name was Obed. "He was the father of Jesse, the father of David" (4:17). The Moabite widow became the great-grandmother of Israel's greatest king.

From Judah to David to Jesus (Ruth 4:18–22; Matthew 1:3–6)



Three outsiders in the line of the King: Tamar, Rahab, and Ruth (Matthew 1:3, 5).
Like many Bible genealogies, this one skips generations. Roughly three centuries separate Rahab and Ruth.

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE Ruth came to take refuge under the wings of the God of Israel (2:12), and she asked Boaz to spread his wings over her (3:9). It is a picture of a bird sheltering its young, and of the cherubim whose wings stretched over the mercy seat (Lesson 10). Jesus used the same picture when he grieved over Jerusalem: "How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings" (Matt. 23:37).

THE LAMB The family line that leads to the promised Offspring keeps running through unlikely people: Tamar, Rahab the Canaanite, Ruth the Moabite. God is preserving a bloodline, and he is also showing that his rescue will reach the nations and that he takes outsiders in.

CORE DOCTRINE 13 OF 26 · GRACE ALONE

Election and Sovereign Grace

Salvation begins with God, not with us. Before the world began God chose a people to save, not because of anything good in them, but out of his own love. He calls outsiders like Ruth, a Moabite widow, into his family. Grace is undeserved, and it is the only reason anyone is saved.

KEY VERSES

Ruth 1:16; 2:10; Ephesians 1:4–5; 2:8–9; John 6:37

WHAT THE CHURCH CONFESSES

"God having, out of his mere good pleasure, from all eternity, elected some to everlasting life, did enter into a covenant of grace." (Westminster Shorter Catechism 20)

WHY IT MATTERS

If grace depended on you, you could lose it. Because it depends on God, those who come to Christ are held fast, and no one who comes is turned away.

The Turn: Our Kinsman-Redeemer and King

Judges leaves us longing for a King who will do right. Ruth leaves us longing for a Redeemer who will pay. Both point to the same Person, born about eleven hundred years later in the same little town of Bethlehem, a descendant of Ruth and Boaz (Matt. 1:5–6).

Remember the three things a redeemer had to be. First, a close relative. So the Son of God became one of us. "Since therefore the children share in flesh and blood, he himself likewise partook of the same things" (Heb. 2:14). He is not ashamed to call us his brothers (2:11). Second, able to pay. Our debt was not silver or gold. "You were ransomed… not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot" (1 Pet. 1:18–19). Third, willing. The nearer relative in Ruth would not risk his own inheritance. Jesus gave up everything. "God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons" (Gal. 4:4–5).

And he is the King Judges was crying out for. The judges rescued Israel for a few years and died. Jesus rose from the dead, and "he is able to save to the uttermost those who draw near to God through him, since he always lives to make intercession for them" (Heb. 7:25). He beats our enemies, and he changes our hearts, so we stop doing what is right in our own eyes and start loving what is right in his.

Maybe you feel like Naomi: you went out full and came back empty. Or maybe you feel like Ruth, an outsider who has no right to be among God's people. The book of Ruth is for you. Come the way Ruth came. Leave your old gods behind and say what Ruth said: "your God my God." Turn from your sin, trust him, and take refuge under his wings. He is your Redeemer, and he is willing.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read Ruth in one sitting.** It takes about twenty minutes. Watch for God at work behind the scenes. The narrator says outright that God acted only twice (1:6; 4:13).

2. **Break your own cycle.** What sin do you keep returning to after God rescues you? Name it to God, and tell one trusted Christian friend.

3. **Pass it on.** Judges 2:10 happened in one generation. Tell a child, grandchild, or younger believer one thing God has done for you.

4. **Look for the "happened."** Write down one moment this week that looked like coincidence. Thank God for his quiet providence.

5. **Be a Boaz.** Show costly kindness to someone on the edges: a widow, a newcomer, someone from another culture.

6. **Memorize Ruth 1:16.** "For where you go I will go, and where you lodge I will lodge. Your people shall be my people, and your God my God."

Before Lesson 14: *Read 1 Samuel 8, 16, and 17, and 2 Samuel 7. Lesson 14 tells how Israel got its first kings, and how God promised David a King who would reign forever.*

For Discussion

1. Judges 2:10 describes a generation that "did not know the LORD." How can faith be lost in a single generation? What guards against it?
2. Where do you see the cycle of Judges in your own life: sin, trouble, crying out, rescue, and back again?
3. God used Gideon and Samson despite their failures. Is that encouraging, troubling, or both? Why?
4. "Everyone did what was right in his own eyes." Where do you see that in our culture? Where do you see it in yourself?
5. Naomi said, "The LORD has brought me back empty." Was she right? How does the rest of the story answer her?
6. Ruth was a Moabite, an outsider by law. What does her place in Jesus' family tree teach about who can belong to God?
7. Walk through the three things a redeemer had to be. How does Jesus fulfill each one?
8. Ruth "happened" into Boaz's field. Where have you seen God's quiet providence in your own story? And why might a book that ends with "no king in Israel" leave us needing more than a human king?

Sources & For Further Study

- On גּאַל and the redeemer laws: Robert L. Hubbard Jr., *The Book of Ruth* (NICOT); Brown, Driver, and Briggs, *Hebrew and English Lexicon*, s.v.
- On the downward spiral in Judges: Daniel I. Block, *Judges, Ruth* (New American Commentary); Dale Ralph Davis, *Judges: Such a Great Salvation*.
- For further reading: Sinclair B. Ferguson, *Faithful God: An Exposition of the Book of Ruth*; Iain M. Duguid, *Esther and Ruth* (Reformed Expository Commentary).



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